of Mohammad or JeM] was formed. Many of the leaders and cadres from these groups could be traced back to the same Deobandi madaris, meaning they not only shared connections with one another but also with the Afghan Taliban.

These three groups—HuJI, HuM and JeM—also shared a connection to the Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan [Army of the Friends of the Prophet or SSP]. Haq Nawaz Jhangvi launched the SSP in 1985, a time when he was serving as the vice-chairman of the JUI in Punjab, to counter Shia influence in Pakistan. The party benefited from the majority of Zia's financing for those Sunni militant groups committed to beating back the Shia tide post-1979. The SSP also used the student body from its madaris in Punjab province to provide recruits for the Afghan jihad against the Soviets and later to the Taliban.[65] It split from the JUI and in 1994 birthed its own militant organization, Lashkar-e-Jhangvi [Army of Jhangvi or LeJ].[66] LeJ spent the late 1980s and all of the 1990s targeting Pakistani Shia, though it too forged ties with the Taliban alongside whom LeJ militants also fought. It became a close al-Qaeda ally after 9/11, and along with its splinter factions is responsible for many of the suicide bombing operations and assassinations that have racked Pakistan in the recent past.

Like the Deobandis, the Ahl-e-Hadith are a product of the colonial context in India where the movement was founded in the 1870s. Its leadership came from prominent families, which had become socially dislocated as a result of British colonization.[67] They too perceived the Muslim community to have strayed from its faith, believing that syncretism, Shiism and the British occupation were corrupting the purity of Sunni Islam. These Muslims condemned the accommodations their co-religionists had made to their Indian surroundings and urged a return to the Quran and Hadith as a way to restore Islam from the corruption of foreign influences.[68]

The Ahl-e-Hadith movement is essentially the South Asian variant of Salafism and the name literally translated means 'people of the Hadith,' which is the text that transmits the path or traditions of the Prophet Mohammad. The term Salafism derives from the name for the first three generations of Muslims, who were known as the al-salaf al-salih or pious forefathers. These men were participants in Islam's rise, and Salafis consider them examples of the correct way for Muslims to live.[69] They